

NEWBORN CARE CHECKLIST

A practical first-weeks planner for new parents

For babies from birth to approximately 6 weeks

This checklist is designed to help parents organize everyday newborn care, appointments, supplies and questions for their healthcare professional.

Important: This is an educational checklist, not a substitute for a pediatrician, nurse or other qualified healthcare professional. For premature, low-birth-weight, unwell or medically complex babies, follow the baby's individualized medical plan.

1. BEFORE BABY COMES HOME

- Confirm the baby's pediatric/newborn follow-up plan and emergency contact numbers.
- Keep the baby's health records, discharge papers and vaccination record together.
- Prepare a safe sleep space: a firm, flat sleep surface with a fitted sheet.
- Wash and prepare essential baby clothes, towels and feeding supplies.
- Keep a digital or paper log for feeds, wet/dirty diapers, medicines prescribed by a clinician, and appointments.
- Ask the healthcare team about any screening tests completed and any results that require follow-up.

2. FIRST HOURS / FIRST DAY

- Ask the healthcare team about skin-to-skin contact when mother and baby are clinically stable.
- Begin breastfeeding as soon as possible when appropriate; get help with positioning and latch if needed.
- Confirm that routine newborn assessments and screening have been completed or scheduled.
- Ask whether vitamin K was given and document it in the baby's records.
- Confirm vaccination/prophylaxis given at birth according to the applicable national/local schedule.
- Ask when the first postnatal/newborn review should occur.

3. FEEDING CHECKLIST

- Feed responsively, following the baby's hunger cues and the healthcare team's advice.
- If breastfeeding is difficult or painful, ask a lactation professional or healthcare provider for help.
- Do not give water, honey or other foods/fluids to a newborn unless advised by a qualified healthcare professional.
- If using formula, follow the product instructions and healthcare guidance exactly; use safe preparation and hygiene.

- Record concerns such as repeated poor feeding, unusual sleepiness, vomiting or difficulty waking for feeds and contact a healthcare professional promptly.

4. CORD & SKIN CARE

- Wash hands before handling the baby or umbilical cord.
- Keep the cord clean and dry and follow the maternity unit's cord-care instructions.
- Do not apply oils, powders, herbs, ash, toothpaste or other substances to the cord unless specifically prescribed.
- Keep the baby's skin clean and dry; avoid unnecessary fragranced products.
- Delay the first bath according to your healthcare team's advice; WHO advises delaying bathing for at least 24 hours when possible.
- Watch for redness spreading around the cord, pus, bad smell or bleeding and seek medical advice if these occur.

5. SAFE SLEEP

- Place baby on the back for every sleep.
- Use a firm, flat sleep surface designed for infants with a fitted sheet.
- Keep pillows, loose blankets, toys, bumpers and other soft objects out of the baby's sleep area.
- Keep the baby's face and head uncovered during sleep.
- Avoid sleeping with the baby on a sofa or armchair.
- Ask your healthcare professional about the safest sleep arrangement for your baby's individual needs.

6. HYGIENE & HOME SAFETY

- Wash hands before feeding, changing or holding the baby, especially after using the toilet or handling waste.
- Keep smoke, vaping aerosols and strong fumes away from the baby.
- Do not leave the baby unattended on beds, sofas, tables or changing surfaces.
- Check bath water temperature and never leave a baby alone near water.
- Use a correctly installed, age-appropriate infant car seat for vehicle travel.
- Keep medicines, cleaning products, hot liquids and small objects out of reach.

7. DAILY BABY CHECK-IN

- Baby feeding reasonably well for them?
- Wet/dirty diapers broadly consistent with healthcare guidance?
- Baby alert and responsive during normal awake periods?
- Breathing appears comfortable?
- Skin colour appears normal for the baby?
- Cord area looks clean and dry?
- Any new rash, fever, vomiting, unusual sleepiness or other concern?
- Write down questions for the next healthcare visit rather than relying on memory.

8. WHEN TO SEEK URGENT MEDICAL CARE

- Baby has trouble breathing, very fast breathing, pauses in breathing, grunting or blue/grey colour.
- Baby is difficult to wake, unusually floppy, has a seizure, or is much less responsive than usual.
- Baby is not feeding well or repeatedly cannot keep feeds down.
- Baby has a fever or unusually low temperature; for a newborn, follow your local medical advice promptly rather than waiting.
- Baby develops jaundice very early, jaundice becomes more pronounced, or yellow colour reaches the palms/soles.
- Baby feels unusually cold or there are signs of serious infection.
- Trust your concern: if something seems seriously wrong, seek urgent medical evaluation.

9. APPOINTMENT & RECORD TRACKER

- Birth date: _____ Birth weight: _____
- First newborn visit: _____ Doctor/clinic: _____
- Next visit: _____ Doctor/clinic: _____
- Vaccination / screening notes: _____
- Feeding questions: _____
- Other questions for pediatrician: _____

10. NEWBORN SUPPLY CHECKLIST

- Fitted sheets for baby's sleep space
- Clean newborn/appropriate-size clothing
- Diapers and changing supplies
- Soft washcloths / towels
- Thermometer suitable for infant use
- Feeding supplies recommended by your healthcare professional
- Baby-safe laundry supplies
- Nappy/diaper disposal supplies
- Infant car seat
- Hand-washing supplies
- Copies/photos of important medical documents and emergency contacts

11. PARENT SELF-CHECK

- I know who to contact if my baby becomes unwell.
- I know where to go for urgent/emergency care.
- I have support for feeding if I need it.
- I am getting opportunities to eat, drink and rest.
- I have told someone I trust if I am feeling overwhelmed.
- I know that asking for help is part of good newborn care.

12. QUICK REFERENCE: 4 QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Is my baby feeding adequately?
2. Is my baby's weight and growth being monitored?
3. Are all recommended screenings and vaccinations up to date?
4. What signs should make me seek urgent medical care?

SOURCES & SAFETY NOTE

This checklist was prepared using general newborn-care principles from the World Health Organization, including essential newborn care, feeding support, hygiene, thermal care, cord care and recognition of danger signs. Vitamin K information is also consistent with CDC guidance. Always follow your baby's clinician and applicable national vaccination/screening schedule.

Reference: WHO — Essential newborn care; WHO — Caring for a newborn; WHO — Infant and young child feeding; CDC — Vitamin K and Breastfeeding. Accessed September 2026.

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